

Two-Factor Authentication Overview

Two-factor authentication is a security method that requires you to confirm your identity while logging into a portal using two distinct factors. This is beneficial because even if a scammer knows your password, they cannot unlock your account.

There are three factors that make up two-factor authentication:

- Something you know, which includes a password or PIN.
- Something you have, which can include your cell phone or passkey.
- Something you are, which includes identifiers like fingerprints, or facial recognition.

A system that uses **two** of these factors qualifies as **two-factor authentication**. Since factors like fingerprints and cell phone codes are hard to steal or replicate, two-factor authentication is extremely helpful when scammers steal a password.

Two-factor authentication typically works this way:

- You enter your username and password.
- You are prompted to complete a second verification step through one of these ways:
 - A notification with a time-sensitive code sent to your email address or phone number.
 - An identifier like a fingerprint or facial recognition.
 - A physical security key inserted into or scanned on the device.

When a two-factor authentication sends a time-sensitive code, this code is usually only valid for that set time frame.

Remember, never tell anyone your one-time verification codes. Legitimate companies will never ask you to share your one-time verification code over the phone or by email.

References

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